Why Hiring Just 3 Engineers Is Harder Than Hiring 300

Simply because someone has hired hundreds of engineers in the last job means nothing if you need to hire just a handful of them. On the contrary, it might be a disqualification

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India has among the largest IT workforce globally and hires several hundreds of thousands of engineers annually. Also, millions of students graduate in India, which is among the highest number of 'qualified' engineers each year. High supply, high demand. So, it should be easy to hire just three engineers.

Wrong!

While it is relatively easy to hire in larger numbers, given that we have such a large pool of graduating engineers available each year, the same logic unfortunately does not work when scaled down! The ease of hiring is, in fact, inversely proportional to the number of unique hires to be done. This is because when you are hiring in hundreds, you are basically hiring 'labour'—engineers who have near-entry-level proficiency of run-of-the-mill mass-market skills (perhaps all of them needing to know textbook Javascript, or classroom SQL, etc) combined with the ability to solve low-level problems (basically responding to a 'ticket' in Jira, such as fixing a UI bug in the website, or making some enhancement to a payroll application, etc) under instructions in an assembly-line fashion. In short, we are referring to everything that a 'knowledge worker' should NOT stand for—a fungible human resource!

On the other hand, when you are hiring in single digits, you are essentially hiring 'talent'—those who have advanced levels of niche skills combined with a high ability to work on their own in an ownership manner. Think of Navy SEALs or equivalent commandos. Think of prohibition agent Eliot Ness working with his small group of elite lawmen going after Al Capone and his gang in The Untouchables. Think of Paul Buchheit creating Gmail in just one afternoon, ramped up only to dozen-odd team when Google decided to launch it. Think of Nikhil Kumar and his